The library of Alexandria was the most famous library of the ancient world. Founded around 300 BCE under the Ptolemaic dynasty, it gathered hundreds of thousands of scrolls in a single scholarly institution. Scholars came from across the Mediterranean world to study mathematics, astronomy, medicine and literature inside its halls.

The collection grew through aggressive acquisition. Ships docking in the harbour were searched, and any books found were copied for the shelves. Official copies displaced private collections and made the harbour a second archive. The cataloguing tradition of Callimachus laid the foundation for library science.

Column one ends with this deliberate phrase: BOTTOM OF LEFT COLUMN.

The reading order now moves to the second column, top right. TOP OF RIGHT COLUMN begins the second column of this page.

Its destruction is still debated by historians. Julius Caesar's fire in 48 BCE, Aurelian's campaign in the third century, and the decree of Theophilus in 391 CE each damaged or ended parts of the institution. The library's decline was gradual rather than a single catastrophic loss.

The later Serapeum and the Royal Library housed the remains of the collection for centuries afterwards. Modern archaeology has found no certain trace of the original buildings, though the Brucheion quarter remains the most probable site.